SEBASTIEN SCHNYDER PORTFOLIO 2026

Born in Geneva in 1990, Sébastien Schnyder is an artist-researcher living and working between Lyon, Geneva and Bassecourt. He trained in photography at CEPV in Vevey before studying ceramic design at the Geneva School of Applied Arts. He went on to pursue visual arts at Villa Arson in Nice, where he obtained a Bachelor's degree followed by a Master's degree in 2023. He is currently a researcher within the ACTH research unit at ENSBA Lyon.

His practice examines the material and symbolic frameworks that structure our environments—not simply to interpret them, but to reveal their tensions and contradictions. Through objects he appropriates, alters, or recomposes, he explores the logics of use, mechanisms of control, and implicit narratives that shape our everyday gestures. Each sculpture and filmed sequence becomes a means of displacement, making visible what, within our environments, presents itself as neutral but is in fact political.

By observing architectures of waiting, industrial infrastructures, and urban systems, he brings to light the ways in which these structures shape our behaviour and organise our relationship to the world. Informed by field research and collaboration with the social sciences, his approach seeks not effect but understanding: understanding how an object acts, how a space imposes itself, and how a fiction structures reality.

His works thus operate as materialised hypotheses, possible scenarios that allow us to think differently about our environments. They open up spaces for discussion and projection, inviting each viewer to reconsider what might otherwise appear self-evident. In this shift of perspective, his practice reminds us that forms are never innocent, and that questioning them always means re-examining the structures that surround us.











On a plateau marked by past and present activities, forms seem suspended between what has been, what is and what might become. Moving between the repeated gestures of a mechanic repairing old trucks and the gathering of discarded fragments, the film explores what persists, transforms or awaits a new use. Tools take shape from these materials as tangible experiments and ambiguous objects, oscillating between reality and fiction, with the potential to become props in a narrative yet to be defined. Gestures, materials and voices come together to form an archaeology of the present, where objects carry the memory of past uses, bear witness to ongoing transformations and open onto possible futures.

Elyse Tunna Curator of What Drift Us Apart by Unfinished Art Space Malta

What the ground keeps, 2026
Docufiction in progress
Lien vidéo
passeword: What_2026





Les Ataviques unfold within a possible prospective archaeology. Buried in the ground, two wooden boxes are embedded in the earth, containing forms that lie somewhere between bones and aircraft fuselages. Made of ceramic and resin, these objects offer no indication of their purpose or their eventual fate.

Les ataviques, 2026
Steel, wood, plexiglass, ceramic, resin
250x245x20 cm

View of the exhibition "Vibration" Arts Ephémère / Centre d'arts Fernand Léger, Port-de-Bouc/ Marseille, September 8 - November 13 2026 Photo credit: Claudia Goletto









The film project and installation Les Ataviques are built around a shared interest in traces, their interpretation, and the construction of narratives from reality. The images in the film, which document archaeological gestures and collective behaviours in a stadium, form an initial body of visual research. The installation offers a material and sculptural extension of this research: through indeterminate forms, somewhere between remnants and fictional objects, it gives shape to the ambiguity between reality and fiction. While the film observes real-life situations and shifts the viewer's perspective on them, the installation gives physical form to objects that could be their traces, witnesses, or remnants of a narrative yet to be invented.

Stadios, 2026
Documentary in progress



Putting Bodies to Work explores the forms of technological support provided to the body and their integration into systems of production. The hip prosthesis, a replacement for a joint, becomes a site of negotiation between repair, adaptation, and the maintenance of the body's productive functions. Raised to hip height, the sculpture evokes both a care apparatus and a tool of labour. Four casts, derived from images of bones and prostheses, repeat the same form, caught between industrial standardisation and organic singularity. Within this tension, the trolley becomes a contemporary reliquary: it displays fragments of bodies transformed into technical objects, at the boundary between the living and the artificial, care and control.

Putting Bodies to Work, 2026
Acier inoxydable, wheels, porcelaine
51 x 84 x 51 cm



View of the exhibition "The Economy of Others / Aponia", October 18 – November 13, 2026. Photo credit: Lucas Zambon.





Drumul Taberei, Bucharest. Built in the late 1960s according to the principles of modernist urban planning, the neighbourhood was designed to accommodate a rural population moving to the outskirts of the city. After decades of socialism, dictatorship, revolution, and the transition to capitalism, its spaces have gradually been transformed and reclaimed by their inhabitants. As part of a research project carried out with the Institut français de Roumanie and Rezidența9, the film explores threshold spaces and the uses that can emerge within them. In Drumul Taberei, these intermediate spaces have notably enabled a particular form of local commerce to develop: former garages located at the foot of residential buildings, gradually transformed into small grocery shops. Among them is La Florica, run by Florin for the past fifteen years and one of the first businesses of its kind in the neighbourhood. Today surrounded by supermarkets and shopping centres, the small shop continues to attract local residents, both for its regional products and for the social relationships that develop there. Over the course of a day, the film follows Florin in his shop. Through his story and that of La Florica, it observes a fragile place, born from the repurposing of urban space and gradually transformed into a place of encounter, proximity, and social interaction. Through the story of a small local shop, the film offers a way of recounting the transformations of a neighbourhood and the forms of use that continue to emerge within the interstices of the city.



La Florica, 2026
Documentary film in progress
2K couleurs 7'30 mintues





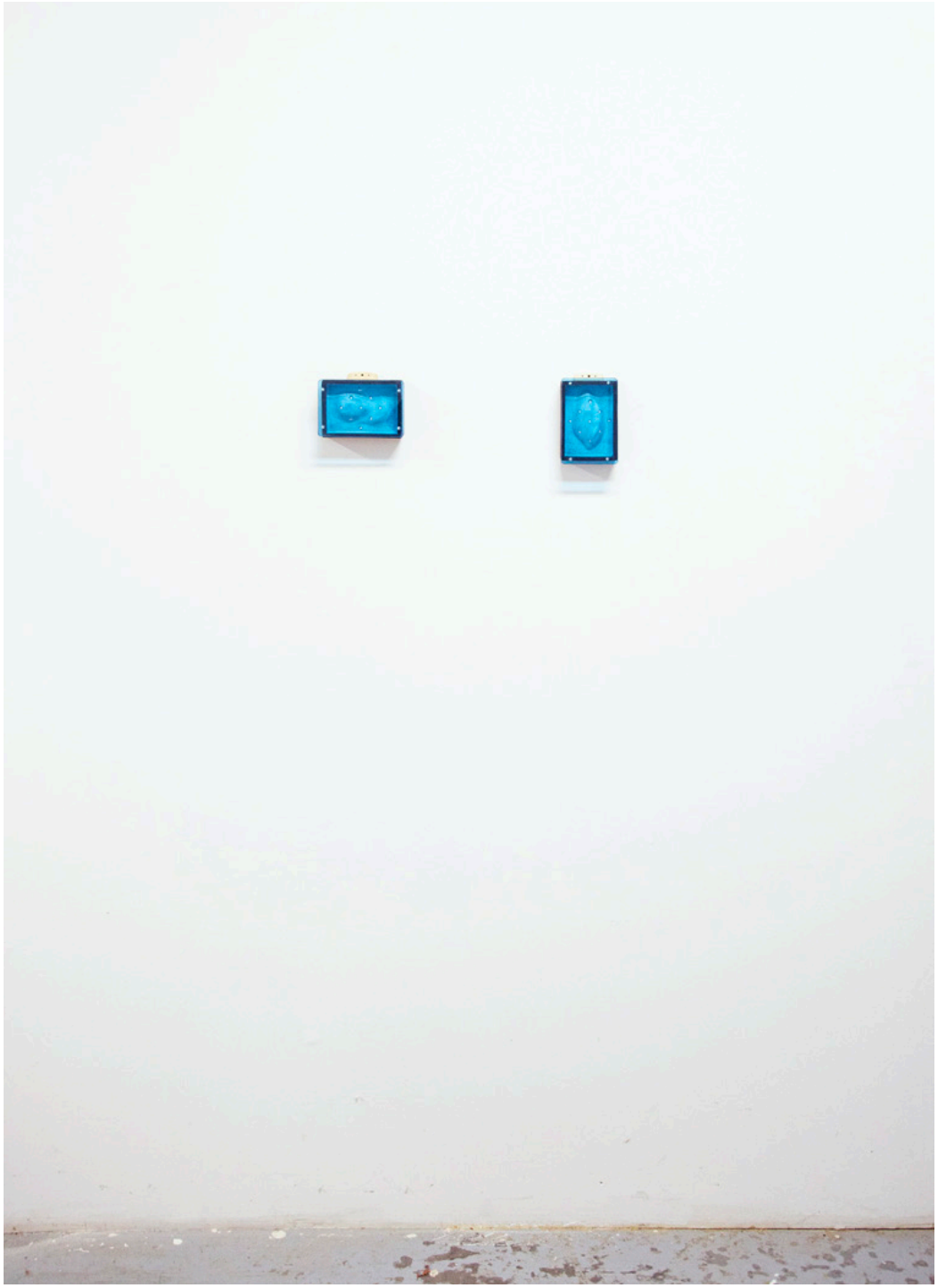
At night, scattered with a bluish glow, the foliage of the vegetation comes alive in a kind of fictional atmosphere. A streetlight, or at least something resembling one, takes the shape of a pentagonal lantern, inspired by the earliest streetlights found in French cities: Veilleureuse. This form revisits the concept of public lighting.

The veilleuses were the people who, during the night, would come to light, inspect, and relight the first streetlamps illuminating Paris. Today, artificial lighting is omnipresent, but what about its impact? This question echoes what we now refer to as light pollution.

Within the context of the Lyon Biennale, near the industrial area of Oullins, a stronghold is keeping plants alive — a kind of second-hand space for vegetation. The SPV (Société Protectrice des Végétaux) serves as a transitional place for these living elements.

The veilleuses thus play a dual role through the concept of keeping watch: protecting and waiting, somewhere between history and science fiction.

Veilleureuse, 2026
Steel, wood, plexiglass, lighting system
280x55x55 cm







Spectrum 1, 2026
Steel, wood, plexiglass, magnets, plaster
15x11.5x5.5 cm

Spectrum 2, 2026
Steel, wood, plexiglass, magnets, plaster
11.5x15x5.5 cm



Installation view of the exhibition
Les sources qui cristallisent
Centre d'art contemporain La Halle des Bouchers, Vienne (FR)
September 20–November 23, 2025
Photo credit: Blaise Adilon.

Sébastien Schnyder's exhibition conceived for La Halle des Bouchers takes the form of a docufiction, centred on a short film accompanied by installations throughout the exhibition space. Sculptural objects extend the narrative developed by the film, exploring notions of flow and passage while inviting us to reconsider our relationship with water, particularly within the city, where now-abandoned architectures—public baths, washhouses, and fountains—stand as silent witnesses to our collective history.

Today, water is increasingly drained away and rendered invisible beneath urban surfaces. Its circulation is accelerated through artificial networks, while streams and rainwater have often disappeared from urban landscapes, perceived as sources of risk, public-health concerns, or flooding.

The artist explores our relationship with water across its natural environments—springs and the places where rivers are born—as well as through sites of capture and control. In one sequence, he films deep inside a dam in the Alps, observing the subterranean and methodical work of the dam operators. From this filmed material, he develops a fiction that engages with the symbolic and spiritual dimensions of high-mountain environments, inviting reflection on the current conditions of glacier melt, the transformation of landscapes, and the memories we retain of them.

Through the staging of sculptural objects, Schnyder extends the research developed through his encounters with glaciologists. Some works evoke ice cores and stalagmites, while others draw on the forms of fountains, washhouses, and urban water pipes—structures in transformation that have sometimes become modern ruins or spaces in transition.

Bernard Collet
Curator



Un court moment, 2025
Wood, concrete, ceramic
300 x 100 x 45 cm









In the Beginning Was the End, 2025
Vidéo HD Couleurs 15 minutes
link viméo
passeword: Fin_2025





Memories, 2025
Steel, ceramic, plexiglass, plastic crate, foam, brass, glass
45 x 62 x 100 cm



Installation view of the exhibition “Les sources qui cristallisent” Centre d’art contemporain La Halle des Bouchers



A.B.Y.S.S.E, 2025
Wood, steel, plaster , plexiglas
183x45x95cm



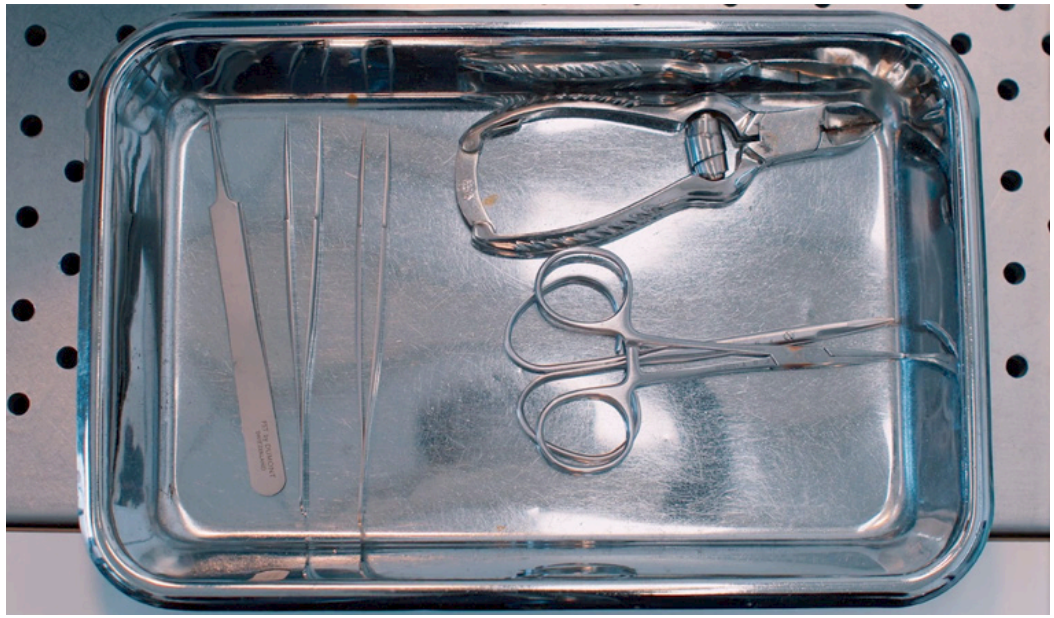


Deliberately omitting a before or an after, the video La Théorie des vieilles bouteilles inhabits an in-between space in which time expands and envelops us, until we too find ourselves waiting. As we wait, both on screen and in the waiting room, nothing happens, or almost nothing. The woman takes off her hat and places it on the empty chair beside her; the man removes his shoe and examines it attentively. Two ordinary yet strangely displaced gestures, reminiscent of those performed by Estragon and Pozzo in the opening lines of Samuel Beckett's play. Through these gestures and other details, a series of clues that we take pleasure in discovering, Sébastien Schnyder flirts with the absurd. Is the territory of waiting the realm of the absurd? In any case, for the artist, it constitutes an interstitial space of freedom and surprise. While nothing seems to make complete sense, it is precisely within the ambiguity and apparent futility of prolonged waiting that meaning is to be found.

Text by Bérangère Amblard, Curatorial Assistant at MAC Lyon

La Théorie des vieilles bouteilles*, 2025*
Installation, HD colour video, 10:42 min
Wood, speaker, screen, ceramic
80x60x165 cm
Link viméo
passeword: Theorie_2025

Installation view of the exhibition "Des lieux qui attendent," at L'Attrape-Couleurs, February 8–April 9, 2025.



In a moment of suspension, objects are handled by a scientist. These tools, used in the medical field, are observed without their precise function ever being defined. We follow the slow process of sterilising these objects. This process raises questions about the ways in which health and hygiene concerns have shaped our environment and our relationship to it. This pursuit of absolute cleanliness, initiated by the hygienist movement of the nineteenth century, continues to shape our cities and contemporary spaces. Yet this obsession with eliminating risk can also lead to the creation of austere and dehumanised environments.

Asepsie / 2024
Vidéo 2K Couleurs 7'30 min
Link viméo
Passeword: Asepsie_26



Installation view of the exhibition "40 + 1," CAP • Centre d'art, 2026. Photo credit: Blaise Adilon.









Attic / 2024
Steel, wood, ceramic, plexiglas
42x88x30 cm

Aria / 2024
Steel, porcelaine
15x45x30

Repos / 2024
Steel, ceramic
25x75x35 cm







Lisle lumineuse is a film about the transformation of a public space through the installation of a fairground attraction. At the heart of the assembly of the ride in a village in the Périgord region, the film captures the metamorphosis orchestrated by a couple who own and operate the attraction. “The canvas awnings unfold, the structures rise, and gradually the empty space fills with a new kind of life. What was once an ordinary place becomes a gathering point where the community comes together, fascinated by this ephemeral spectacle.” The act of assembling becomes a possibility. Here, everything seems to take on an allegorical dimension, and the appearance of the fairground ride could embody everyone’s ability to appropriate a territory and transform it into a moment of exception.

Text by Guillaume Mansart for the exhibition “La Relève 7” at Château de Servières

Lisle lumineuse / 2024
Vidéo HD Couleurs
23 minutes
Link: https://vimeo.com/954309798
Ppasseword: Lisle_2024



Crédit photo: Oriane Coton





Vitrine,2023
vidéo HD 7'24 minutes
Link viméo

En attendant / 2023
Wood, steel, soil, plants, glass
150x108x200 cm



« Sweet Days of Discipline», 2024, centre d'art contemporain - Villa Arson, crédit photo Jeanchristophe Lett / Villa Arson Nice





Taking acoustic mirrors as a point of reference, we decided to create two sculptures that would speak of sound without emitting any. Before the Second World War and the invention of radar, acoustic mirrors were built as early-warning devices along the coast of Great Britain. They made it possible to hear approaching aircraft from a distance, far beyond the capabilities of the “human ear” alone.

The vocabularies of sculpture and sound share common ground: both speak of matter, noise, texture, and these notions can equally be applied to the sculptural medium. Here, we use the language of sculpture, which, although silent, is not devoid of meaning. We constructed two blocks, each with one reflective and one absorptive surface: one smooth, with a parabola suggesting the reflection of sound; the other evoking noise, waves, and raw matter. Their spatial arrangement can also vary according to the context in which they are exhibited: back to back, face to face, or standing independently. With this project, the aim is not to reproduce the appearance of reality, but rather to express the dynamics and active relationship we maintain with a living reality.

A cappella, 2022
Steel, ceramics
2 sculpturs : 65x86×160cm
Artwork created in collaboration with Béatrice Guilleman

Installation view of the exhibition “Resonating Ceramics 2023,” Centre National d’Art Contemporain – Villa Arson, Nice.

Crédit photo: Jean-Christophe Lett / Villa Arson Nice



View of the exhibition City of Geneva Grants 2022 at the Centre d'Art Contemporain Genève (02.09–02.10.2022). © Centre d'Art Contemporain Genève. Photo credit: Julien Girard

Close to the sterile, white domestic partitions that homogenize our interiors, these sculptures are punctured by cavities and absences. These voids derive from casts made in situ from historical stones, including a milestone from the Via Julia Augusta, the Roman road connecting Rome to present-day Salon-de-Provence. By incorporating these imprints, the work introduces a vernacular and constructive memory into the heart of contemporary materials.

The hollow bodies are never complete: something is missing from them, a part, a presence. Their incompleteness opens up a space for reflection in which the relationship between solid and void, interior and exterior, body and architecture is re-enacted. From this perspective, Les corps creux function as “double-functioning elements”: architectural fragments, they are also bodily forms, a torso, a folded arm, a slumped body.

As they oxidize and transform, the materials reveal the active role of entropy and remind us that architecture, like the body, is always in the process of becoming.



Les corps creux 2/ 2023
resin, steel, oxides
55x45x165 cm



the exhibition Melting Pot. From the Alchemical Crucible to the Cultural Melting Pot © Musée d'art et d'histoire de Neuchâtel. Photo credit: Nicolas Lieber

Building is a fundamental activity in the history of humanity, yet paradoxically, this activity contributes to our own ruin. The reinforcing steel used in most constructions is also the cause of their fragility: it rusts, then bursts apart. Built to a limited lifespan, our buildings have become little more than objects, commodities whose obsolescence is programmed.

In this context, the imitation metal bars speak of architecture, of the theme of contemporary ruins, and of the inner structure of concrete. They also evoke the skeleton, by analogy with the body—our bodies, as well as those of the structures through which we move. The metal bars trace the contours of a space where, for a fleeting moment, interior and exterior exist side by side, where past and present intermingle.

Catalogue text for the exhibition Melting Pot. From the Alchemical Crucible to the Cultural Melting Pot at the Musée d'art et d'histoire de Neuchâtel.

Structurel / 2022
Ceramics
Variable dimensions







mue / 2021
Latex, wood, talc
Dimension variable

Porosité / 2021
wood, plaster,steel
255 x 365 x 255 cm





L'informe, 2021
Metal shelving unit, cardboard boxes, wax, heating element, Arduino processor.
110 x 60 x 200 cm